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The Number Line

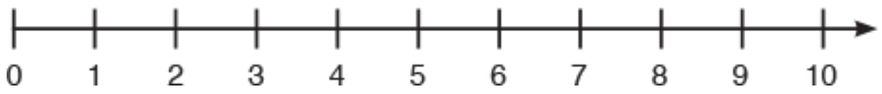
The Number Line

Toolbox

The Number Line

One way to show numbers and their relationship to each other is on a **number line.** The markings on a number line divide the line into equal spaces. The arrows on a number line show that the numbers continue.

The number line below shows the **whole numbers** from 0 to 10. The set of whole numbers starts at 0 and includes the numbers you use for counting. On this number line, each mark represents 1.



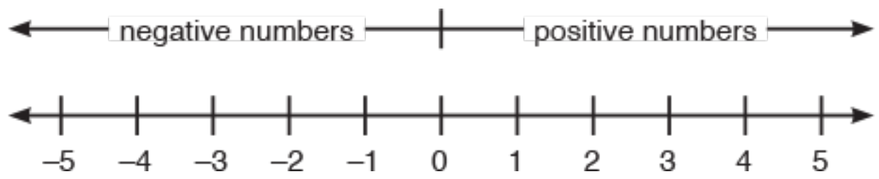
In the following number line, we have zoomed in on the space between 0 and 1 where fractions or decimals would be located. Here, each space represents $\frac{1}{4}$.



Values increase as you move to the right along the number line. What happens when you move to the left? They decrease.

Algebra includes the use of **signed numbers**. Signed numbers are either **positive** or **negative**. A negative number is written with a − sign.

A negative number has a value less than 0. Negative numbers are written to the left of 0.



Note: 0 is neither positive nor negative.

Positive numbers, to the right of 0, can be written with or without a + sign. Both +5 and 5 mean "positive 5." A negative number must be written with a − sign.

Sometimes a negative number will have parentheses to help you see that the negative sign is attached to the number. Both −2 and (−2) mean "negative 2."

Key Terms

- **whole numbers**
- **signed numbers**
- **negative**
- **integer**
- **positive**
- **decimal point**

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Category
Lesson 1: Number Sense

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